

Douching

Douching is the internal cleansing of the vagina using water or mixtures of fluids such as baking soda, iodine, or vinegar. People may douche to remove odors, “feel fresh,” cleanse after menstruation, or try to reduce the risk of infection.

Why doctors advise against douching

Despite its popularity, medical professionals strongly advise against douching. It disrupts the natural balance of bacteria in the vagina, which can lead to:

- Bacterial vaginosis
- Yeast infections
- Pelvic inflammatory disease (PID)
- Problems getting pregnant

A healthy vagina naturally contains both good and harmful bacteria. Maintaining this balance helps keep the vagina acidic and protected from infections and irritation. Douching interferes with this balance and can make symptoms worse.

Should I douche to get rid of vaginal odor or infection?

No. You should not douche to treat vaginal odor or symptoms like discharge, itching, pain, or irritation.

Douching may temporarily hide odor, but it does not treat the underlying cause and often makes problems worse.

Contact a doctor if you notice:

- Vaginal discharge with a bad smell
 - Vaginal itching with thick, white, or yellowgreen discharge
 - Burning, redness, or swelling in or around the vagina
 - Pain when urinating
 - Pain or discomfort during sex
-

What is the best way to clean my vagina?

The vagina is selfcleaning. It produces mucus that naturally removes blood, semen, and discharge.

If you are concerned about vaginal odor, talk to a doctor or nurse. Even healthy vaginas have a mild odor that can change throughout the day. Physical activity can also create a stronger, muskier scent—this is normal.

How to keep your vagina clean and healthy

- Wash only the outside of your vagina (vulva) with warm water when bathing.
- Some women use mild, unscented soaps, but if you have sensitive skin or a current infection, even mild soap can cause dryness and irritation.
- Avoid scented tampons, pads, powders, wipes, and sprays. These products may increase your chances of vaginal irritation or infection.